

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

ALT this month:

We kick off the section this month by giving you a rundown of all kinds of westerns there can be. Right after that, we move on to show you how Bandersnatch from Netflix wasn't really that special. Don't forget to check out a visual story on how many foreign satellites ISRO has launched, in the Infoporn section!



Multiple headed Hydra

Scientists have recreated mythology by manipulating the genetic code of the hydra, to grow multiple heads. The tiny organism is practically immortal, and can regenerate its entire body even after being cut into tiny pieces. Disrupting this regeneration mechanism allows it to grow multiple heads. <https://digit.in/hydraheads>

WHAT'S NEW

DNA ancestry kits fail test by twins

To test out the effectiveness of publicly available genetic testing services, a pair of twins sent in samples of their DNA to five companies for analysis. Despite having almost the same DNA, the results from all the five companies did not register a match. According to the tests, the twins had ancestry tracing back to different parts of the world. According to experts, the DNA results from the companies for both the sisters, should have been almost identical. A team of researchers from Yale went ahead and obtained the raw data sets that the companies used to analyse the data. Surprisingly, while the raw data was nearly identical for both the twins, for all the five companies, the results, or ancestry breakdowns



provided by the companies were not the same. The researchers suspect that the fault lies in the data processing algorithms that the companies used, but are not sure. In conclusion, these DNA testing kits are best restricted to recreational science.

<https://digit.in/twintest>

Dead drops and the dark net markets

The dark net sellers are moving away from the underbelly of the internet, and onto more conventional instant messaging platforms, such as Telegram. The dark net marketplaces are prone to surveillance and takedowns, and the merchants have more control over the interaction channels on the IM clients. Automation via chatbots is easy, and regular customers can be moved to private channels that are even more resilient to takedowns and



surveillance. Instead of using the postal service the dark net merchants are moving to dead drops. The parcels are stashed in public places, such as parks, and then the location is provided to

the customer after the payment is done. This reduces the risk, as no personally identifiable information is exchanged during the entire transaction. The customer also can get the delivery within a matter of hours. The seller can stash away the parcels in advance, and quickly direct any new customers to the locations. The organisations emerging to support this new market model are being called drop gangs.

<https://digit.in/dropgangs>



Amazon's robotic tech vest

Amazon warehouses can be pretty dangerous. Amazon has introduced electronic safety vests, designed to make interactions with robots safer. This is for when the employees have to pick up items dropped by the robots, or have to repair the robots themselves. <https://digit.in/robovest>



Smart cat bowl

A smart pet feeding bowl uses artificial intelligence and facial recognition to dispense the right amount of food for the right pet. This bowl ensures that your pets do not get obese. The bowl is also linked to an app, that allows pet owners to figure out the eating habits of their pets, and to figure out if they are ill. <https://digit.in/aipetbowl>



Creepy medical devices

Blades that cut through arteries, clusters of needles that caused rashes, and machines that sprayed carbolic acid into the operating theatre to sterilize the environment. Discover bizarre apparatus from when bloodletting and leechcraft were a part of healthcare. <https://digit.in/medcreep>